



▲ THE TURQUOISE WATERS OF LAGUNA 69

River plunges vertically 741 ft (226 m) over a resistant conglomerate lip atop a sandstone cliff. The water splashing at the bottom is eroding the less resistant sandstone, creating an overhang. The river then thunders down a further series of cascades into a 20-mile- (32-km-) long gorge. Although many waterfalls are higher, what makes Kaieteur remarkable is its volume of flow, averaging 23,400 cubic feet (663 cubic meters) per second.

Laguna 69

Location Huascarán National Park, Ancash region, central Peru

Probably the most beautiful of Huascarán National Park's 400-plus lakes, what Laguna 69 (Laguna Sesentineuve) lacks in size it more than makes up for in its setting. The lake's turquoise

color is produced by fine sediment that has been eroded and transported by glaciers. It lies at an elevation of 15,100 ft (4,600 m) and is surrounded by snow-clad mountains. In summer, the lake is replenished by a waterfall plunging down the slopes of Chakraraju. In winter, it is frozen. Most of the national park's lakes did not have traditional names, hence the numeric designation.

Tres Hermanas Falls

Location Otishi National Park, Junin, central Peru

After Angel Falls in Venezuela and Tugela Falls in South Africa, this is the third highest waterfall in the world and one of only three to attain a total drop of 3,000 ft (915 m). Tres Hermanas, or "Three Sisters," carries an unnamed

Andean stream over a three-stepped drop in an area of undisturbed rain forest. Water plunges down the first two tiers into large, natural catch basins, before the final drop deposits water into the Cutivireni River.

The Cotahuasi River

Location Arequipa region between the Altiplano and the Ocona River, southwest Peru

One of the best whitewater kayaking rivers on Earth, the Cotahuasi's modest source is high on the Altiplano. It descends quickly over rapids and waterfalls through the Cotahuasi Canyon—one of the world's deepest canyons, reaching a maximum depth of 11,486 ft (3,501 m)—before merging with the Maran River to form the Ocona, Peru's largest

river, flowing into the Pacific. In 150 miles (240 km), the Cotahuasi descends 11,500 ft (3,500 m).

The Colca River

Location Arequipa region between the Andean Altiplano and Pacific Ocean, southwest Peru

On the Colca river's 280-mile (450-km) journey from the high mountains of the western Andes to the Pacific Coast, it descends 14,800 ft (4,500 m) and has three different names—Colca, Majes, and Camana. The Colca's main claim to fame, though, is flowing through the Colca Canyon, one of the world's deepest. At its deepest point, the river is at least 11,500 ft (3,500 m) below the summits on either side. The canyon is 70 miles (120 km) long and is famed for its whitewater rafting.